Capturing a particularly Indian perspective on international affairs is intrinsically difficult. Outsiders have often sought to interpret India, but with rare exceptions such works often impose their own lenses. The task of presenting a singular Indian perspective is, of course, complicated by the diverse and sometimes sharp debates and differences of opinion within India on almost any given issue. But while acknowledging that difficulty, I have attempted to channel the vantage point of policymakers and leaders in India, past and present. If it sometimes strikes an overly sympathetic note, it is primarily to offset the inevitability of hindsight.

While this book is not strictly an academic work, it does attempt to address and engage academic discourse on India's foreign relations. For many reasons, scholarship on India in international politics has not always kept pace with developments. Indeed, academic studies frequently fall back on outdated clichés and enduring myths that do not necessarily reflect the new realities and impulses guiding India's relations with the world. These include the notions that India's world view remains grounded in Non-Alignment, that it lacks the capacity to be a great power, that it seeks prestige or status rather than power or influence, and that it must sort out its internal or regional challenges before it can move on to global aspirations. The historical narrative and analysis presented here should hopefully disabuse readers of some of these questionable notions.

A further motivation, therefore, is to update India's strategic vocabulary. It is evident that India has gradually transitioned from the Non-Alignment of India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, to something quite different after 1991. The contours of India's post-Cold War foreign policy are clearly discernible, and include an emergence from relative economic isolationism, a refocus on a more dynamic Asia and Indo–Pacific, closer and more comprehensive relations with the United States and its allies (such as Japan, Australia, Europe, and Israel), and the dedicated pursuit of nuclear security. Subsequently, after its nuclear tests of 1998, India's changing foreign policy also saw it gradually distinguish (or 'de-hyphenate') itself from Pakistan and become less hesitant about projecting itself as a rising global power. Non-Alignment—at least as it was originally envisioned—